

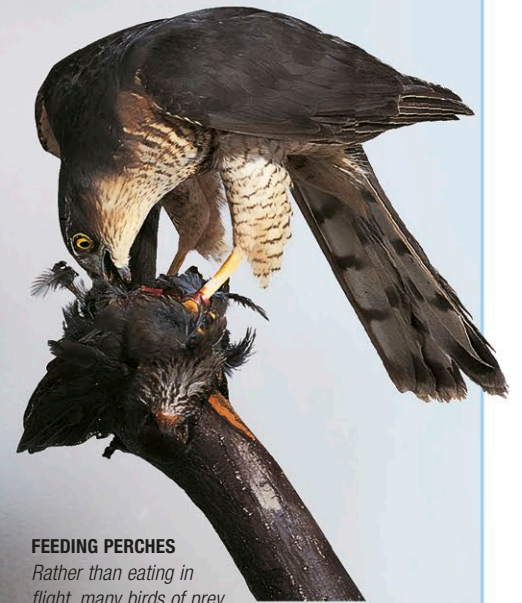
Feeding

Most birds of prey feed on live animals; the larger the species, the larger the prey that they are able to carry. The bald eagle, for example, is capable of taking a deer fawn if it is not too heavy. Many birds of prey are specialized feeders, including the honey buzzard (which eats wasps and their grubs), and the secretary bird (which eats snakes). As well as live prey, many species also eat carrion from time to time. A few, such as vultures and kites, feed almost entirely on dead animals. One carrion-feeder, the bearded vulture, eats bones, breaking the larger ones by dropping them onto rocks. The palm-nut vulture, named after its favorite food, is unusual in that it feeds mainly on plants.



CARRION-FEEDERS

Up to 6 species of vultures may gather around a carcass at one time, each feeding on different parts of the body. For example, some may feed on soft body parts, while others eat the skin and hide. The lappet-faced vulture (left) is one of the largest species and is often dominant over others.



FEEDING PERCHES

Rather than eating in flight, many birds of prey carry their kill to a favored perch, where they carefully remove all unpalatable parts before eating it. This European sparrowhawk (above) is plucking a blackbird.

Flight

All birds of prey are able fliers.

They use different patterns of flight to suit the way they hunt. Using their large, broad wings to ride thermals or updrafts next to cliffs, vultures and condors can stay aloft for hours, barely flapping their wings and using their high vantage point to search for carrion. In contrast, the smaller raptors may attack other birds in midair, maneuvering on long, thin, pointed wings and sometimes diving (or stooping) from a great height (see below). Hawks plan their strikes and then use a burst of speed to surprise or ambush prey. Harriers fly slowly forward over the ground and then drop onto unsuspecting prey. Kestrels and buzzards can hover in one place, watching for movement below and then lunging downward, talons first.



AERIAL KILLER

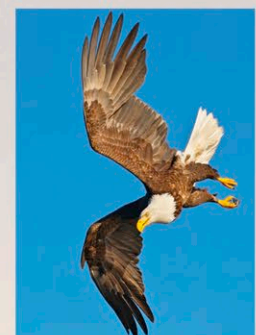
One of the most distinctive features of birds of prey is the way they kill with their feet, seizing prey from the ground, water, or air. Steller's sea eagle (seen here) uses its feet to catch Pacific salmon. It also hunts geese, hares, and young seals.

SOARING

Condors and vultures have the largest wings of all birds of prey (the bearded vulture, above, has a wingspan of up to 9¾ ft/3 m). Both are common in mountainous areas, where rising currents of air help keep them aloft.

DIVING

Large eagles of open country, with little cover to conceal them from their prey, use a low, fast pursuit, often followed by a short, powerful stoop. Bald eagles also dive acrobatically to take fish from water using their feet.



CONSERVATION



Many birds of prey are threatened by human activity. Most are listed by CITES, and they include some of the world's most endangered animals, such as the California condor, with a current population of just over 400. Even widespread species are vulnerable because they are at the top of food chains. They are also routinely persecuted, because of the perceived threat they pose to livestock. Also, widespread use of diclofenac, a chemical used for treating cattle, has reduced South Asian populations of vultures by more than 90 percent. Despite the availability of safe options, the chemical has recently been licensed for use in Africa and Iberia.